

Problems Overview

Introduction

The Port of Dover is the UK’s busiest international ferry port, linking southeast England to France across a 34 km route [1]. It handles around 9 million passengers and over 2 million freight vehicles each year [2]. Its fast processing and frequent sailings, running roughly every 30 minutes, make it a critical cross-channel hub [3].

Impact

The port moves about £144 billion of goods annually, representing nearly one-third of UK–EU traded goods [4]. It also handles roughly 31% of all seaborne HGV traffic [4], making it essential for manufacturers, retailers, and logistics operators. Operational efficiency generates an estimated £3 billion in annual transport cost savings through faster crossings and more reliable schedules [4]. The port also supports thousands of jobs and underpins the regional economy in Kent [5].

Stakeholders

- **Dover Harbour Board:** Manages and operates the port [1].
- **Ferry Operators:** P&O Ferries, DFDS, and Irish Ferries [3].
- **Border Agencies:** UK Border Force and French Police Aux Frontières operate juxtaposed border checks [6].
- **Local and Transport Authorities:** Kent Police, National Highways, and the Kent Resilience Forum coordinate traffic and resilience planning [7].

Queuing Process

Arriving vehicles pass through check-in and passport control before entering marshalling lanes for boarding [1]. Traffic flow is monitored through real-time sensor systems [8]. During peak demand, external controls are used:

- **Dover TAP:** Holds HGVs on the A20 under a 40 mph limit to reduce town congestion [9].
- **Operation Brock:** Uses a section of the M20 as a controlled queuing zone during severe disruption [7].

Bottlenecks

Delays occur when demand exceeds processing capacity, often due to weather, ferry disruption, or extended post-Brexit passport checks. Cars may take around 90 seconds to clear French controls, and coaches up to 20 minutes [10]. This has resulted in severe peak delays, including six-hour queues for cars in 2022 and up to 18 hours for coaches in 2023 [11, 10]. Such congestion also disrupts local roads and affects nearby businesses [5].

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